In May 1857, several hundred mutinous sepoys and cavalrymen rode into Delhi from Meerut and instigated the local troops. Together they massacred every British resident that they could find. Indian converts to Christianity were not spared either. As more and more rebels arrived, the soldiers turned to the ageing emperor for leadership. Bahadur Shah was personally ambivalent about the offer. On one hand, he was scared that the British would return and exact retribution. On the other hand, he was faced with a large and growing number of rebels who would probably break into a riot if he refused. He opted to play along with the rebels, but would remain indecisive throughout the episode.

Meanwhile, a small British force had arrived and set up a defensible position on the ancient Aravalli ridge overlooking the walled city. From here they proceeded to pound Shahjahanabad with artillery. Their numbers were small but the disorganized rebels were unable to make a concerted attempt to capture the position. A contingent of Gurkha soldiers held off waves of rebel attacks near Burra Hindu Rao's house on top of the ridge; it's now a hospital. One of the princes, Mirza Mughal, did try to organize the mutineers, but was constantly undermined by the indecisive emperor and by the internal jealousies of his own family. It is amazing how the British had a constant flow of information from collaborators within the walled city throughout the siege. [11]

From mid-August, the British were being reinforced by fresh troops and supplies from Punjab. The artillery pounding was ramped up. A month later, Shahjehanabad had been captured and sacked. The game was over. Bahadur Shah and members of his family, proud descendants of Taimur the Lame and Ghengis Khan, fled down the Yamuna to take shelter in Humayun's grand tomb. It is not clear why they bothered since it is barely a few miles south of the city. The British soon caught up with them. Many Mughal princes were executed. Three of them, including Mirza Mughal, were stripped naked and shot dead with a Colt revolver near the archway still called Khuni Darwaza (Gate of Blood). The emperor himself was exiled to Rangoon.